questions like “is this principal in that team?” or “who is the manager of this employee?” Edges allow the store to answer these questions directly, often using indexes or ancestor caches, without loading and scanning large attributes. This keeps evaluations fast, policies simple, and the schema clean. Updates become just changes to the graph—adding or removing an edge—rather than rewriting entity definitions.

Using `Set<Principal>` attributes can be effective for small, static lists or special cases like temporary whitelists, but they don’t scale well and complicate maintenance and explanation. By maintaining membership within the relationship graph, ACME’s authorization model remains flexible, adaptable to organizational changes, and simpler to understand, regardless of the underlying storage technology.